EMUNOT VEDEOT: SAADIAH GAON'S BOOK OF BELIEFS AND OPINIONS

# What Is the Soul? Six Wrong Answers

**Given Monday 3 March 2025** · Emunot VeDeot, Essay 6:1

**Sefer:** Emunot VeDeot (The Book of Beliefs and Opinions) by Rav Saadia Gaon

**Essay/Chapters:** Essay 6 (The Soul, Death and What Follows), Chapter 1

**Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Monday series on Emunot VeDeot, Monday 3 March 2025, on Zoom

*These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.*

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## The Sixth Essay: A Bridge Between the Two Halves of the Book

The sixth essay is "really a bridge between the two sections of the book." It has eight chapters:

| Chapters | Subject |
|---|---|
| **1 to 5** | The **essence and nature of the soul** |
| **6 and 7** | What happens to the soul **as we die and after death** |
| **8** | **Reincarnation**: "probably a bit of a surprise to some of you, what Saadia is going to say about gilgul" |

### Where the essay sits

| Essay | Subject |
|---|---|
| 1 | The universe and its creation ("the beginning, last year at this time") |
| 2 | God: His essence, His attributes, anthropomorphism |
| 3 | Revelation: Torah and prophecy |
| 4 | Free will |
| 5 | Merits and demerits |
| **6** | **The soul** |
| 7 | *Techiyat hametim*, resurrection |
| 8 | Mashiach |
| 9 | The world to come |
| 10 | Mussar: advice on how to be a good person |

The first five essays established that there is a creation, that there is a God, that He revealed Himself, that we have free will, and therefore that we must choose wisely. Essays 7 to 9 are about the result of those choices: resurrection, Mashiach and Olam HaBa. "But who's going to enjoy that? The *nefesh*. What's the *nefesh*?"

The soul is one of the three great philosophical questions, with creation and God, and "really that should have come before," but Saadia places it here as the segue into what happens to the soul afterwards.

"I have to be honest with you. Specifically the first chapter is very difficult, it's very philosophical. I'll do my best to explain as much as I was able to understand." As with creation in Essay 1, where he went through thirteen theories, Saadia first lists the theories of what the soul is and tries to disprove them, and only in Chapter 2 gives his own.

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## Saadia's Opening Statement

Saadia writes that Hashem has informed us that **the soul of a person is created in his heart upon the completion of his body**, as the verse says, **ויצר רוח אדם בקרבו**, "He forms the spirit of man within him," the *ruach* that Saadia identifies with the soul.

- **When?** "I don't know if that means in the womb or when the child is born." The Rabbi thought it probably means when the being is formed in the mother's womb, and grows together with it.
- Body and soul are **joined for the duration of a person's life**. When that time ends, they **separate**.
- They remain separate **until the number of souls God intends to create is complete**. Then He **reunites them for the world to come**.

"We have the prophets who tell us about this. Now we're going to try to understand this rationally and philosophically, like we do every essay."

### Two things to notice straight away

1. **Olam HaBa is body and soul together.** Saadia will say so explicitly later, but it is implied here. The Rambam, as the class learnt at length in Hilchot Teshuvah, holds that Olam HaBa is **the soul alone**.
2. **Olam HaBa is a world still to come.** For Saadia, and for many who followed him, including the **Ramchal** in *Derech Hashem*, Olam HaBa is a future world that does not yet exist. When a person dies now, the soul waits in what is commonly called **Gan Eden**, "like a kind of waiting room." For the Rambam, Gan Eden and Olam HaBa are synonymous: you die, and you are in Olam HaBa. It is called "the world to come" not because it does not exist yet, but because it comes after this life. The Rambam has a specific halachah to negate the other view, "because this was a very common belief," and he knew Saadia, whom he quotes. The class will see more in Essays 7 and 9.

### A question from Mark: new souls

**Mark** asked when the soul enters. The Rabbi would imagine at conception, though Saadia is not bound by the various Midrashim on the soul in the womb. Mark then noted that if Hashem continues creating souls until the full number is reached, every soul is new, which implicitly negates **gilgul**. "You're right, a hundred percent." But Saadia will negate reincarnation in far stronger terms: Chapter 8 is devoted to refuting it, and "he completely ridicules" it.

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## Eleven Theories, Seven Discussed

"The first thing we have to do is try to understand the essence of the soul." Many philosophers have debated it. Saadia says he will not mention most of the many views. He brings **seven**, in addition to **four** he already dealt with in Essay 1, making **eleven** in all.

### The four from Essay 1

| | Theory of creation | Implication for the soul |
|---|---|---|
| 1 | God created the world from **pre-existing eternal matter** (Plato's view) | The soul is made from that matter |
| 2 | God created the world **from His own essence** | The soul is from God's essence |
| 3 | God created from **Himself combined with another essence** | |
| 4 | **Two deities** created the world between them | |

Since Saadia has already refuted these, and holds that the soul is a **new creation** God has made, he does not repeat the refutations.

Everyone agrees that we have a *nefesh*: "whatever life force gives us, allows us to live, as opposed to when we're dead and we just have a dead body." The question is what it is.

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## Theory 1: The Soul Is an Accident

The first theory is that the soul is not a substance at all but an **accident**.

| Term | Meaning |
|---|---|
| עצם (*etzem*) | A **substance**, a separate entity created together with the body |
| מקרה (*mikreh*) | An **accident**: a consequence or property of the body, like the ability to stand or sit. You have the body, and as a result it has a soul |

Those who held this did so because no one has ever seen the soul, only its functions. It is too fine to be sensed, "just like you can't feel the concept of sitting or standing."

Within this theory Saadia lists **five types**. The Rabbi researched who held each ("I'm no expert in this stuff"):

| | The soul is… | Associated with |
|---|---|---|
| 1a | **A self-moving number** | **Xenocrates**, a student of Plato and a mathematician who saw everything as mathematics: "number" for the capacity to know, "self-moving" because through the soul we live and move |
| 1b | **The completion and perfection of the body** | **Aristotle** |
| 1c | **The balanced combination of the four natures** (blood, phlegm, black bile, yellow bile) | **Hippocrates**, the physician; the Rambam often quotes the four natures |
| 1d | **The coordination of the senses** | |
| 1e | **Something resulting from the blood** | Not that the soul *is* the blood (that is Anan's view, below) |

### Aristotle's axe

The Rabbi read Aristotle's view from a summary on screen. The soul is the structure and functioning of the body. There is a hierarchy: plants with a vegetative soul, animals above them with appetite, humans above animals with reason.

**The axe:** its body is wood and metal; its "soul" is its **capacity to chop**. If it loses that, it is no longer an axe, just wood and metal. **The eye:** if the eye were an animal, sight would be its soul. When it no longer sees, it is an eye in name only. So too a dead animal is an animal in name only: same body, no soul.

For Aristotle body and soul are not two separate things. "The completion of the creation of the human, when it's all working and it's all together, is what we call its soul… It's not something separate."

**What the five share:** the soul is not a separate entity but a result of the body. A participant observed that the middle three are the most alike, each a coordination or completion; the first is a different kind of description, "and also the fifth."

### Saadia's two refutations

1. **Something accidental cannot be the source of such wisdom and glory.** The human being has great wisdom, through which he can change the world. The Rabbi was "almost certain" Saadia refers back to the opening of Essay 4, where he spent chapters showing that the human is the pinnacle of creation (which the Rambam and Ibn Ezra disputed). Such a being cannot be a mere by-product; the soul must be a **separate substance**.
2. **An accident cannot itself bear accidents.** Many things happen to the soul: love, hatred, will, anger; a soul is happy or sad, wise or foolish, pure or bad. These are all **accidents of the soul**, things that happen to it. If the soul were itself only an accident, these could not be attributed to it. Since they are, **the soul must be a substance**.

"If you don't fully understand this, it's fine. I also don't fully understand all of it. The main thing is the concepts."

### Doron's question: accident and intention

**Doron** asked whether calling the soul an "accident" means Hashem made it unintentionally. The Rabbi: no. On this theory Hashem did intend it, but He made the body as the main thing, and the soul is a resulting by-product. Saadia's objection is that for so glorious a being, the soul must be "much more central and integral and substantial than just being a *mikreh*, a side point." Doron pressed that Hashem created the whole human with intention, soul included. The Rabbi agreed that everything God does is intentional; the issue is direct versus indirect. A participant added the verse: Hashem formed a body from earth, **and blew into it**. Before that "it's not human yet... it was earth." The Rabbi: "Exactly. It's direct, intentional, it's a substance." But he reminded the class that Saadia is arguing here from reason, not bringing verses.

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## Theories 2 and 3: The Soul Is Air, or Fire

Some philosophers held that the soul is **air** (the Rabbi found this attributed to **Diogenes**); others, apparently **Democritus**, that it is **fire**.

Saadia: if the soul were air, its nature would be **warm and moist**; if fire, **warm and dry**. We do not find these to be the nature of the soul. The class struggled with what this means. "These are very old concepts. Even the Rambam talks about moisture."

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## Theory 4: Two Souls, Rational and Animal

The soul has **two parts**:

- the **rational, intellectual** part, which is **eternal** and dwells **in the heart**;
- the **animal** part, which is **spread throughout the body** and is **not eternal**.

The Rabbi found it attributed to **al-Baqillani**, an early Muslim theologian around Saadia's time. "This is starting to sound closer to what we're used to hearing," and a participant immediately made the connection: **the Kabbalah**, with its **five parts of the soul**, the *nefesh* as the animal part and higher parts above it. "Precisely, you're very good, well done."

Saadia rejects any division of the soul:

- If the rational and the animal souls were separate, they could not come together. One is eternal and one is not; they are entirely different.

- If the rational part sits in the heart and the animal part is diffused through the senses, **the intellect could not perceive anything the senses feel**.
- And if you answer that the intellect **coordinates** the animal soul's sensations, two distinct things cannot be coordinated in that way. "I'm sticking with my problem."

"This is really important, because this means Saadia rejects outright the concept of their being parts to a soul."

For Saadia the soul has **many names, which are synonyms**: one soul with five names. The Kabbalists saw the different names as **different aspects or levels** of the soul.

The Rabbi reminded **Mark** of a question he had asked when the class learnt the **Ramchal**: the Ramchal says the soul comes from Hashem, and just as Hashem is one, the soul is one. How does that fit with his speaking elsewhere of different elements? For Saadia there is no tension: the soul comes from Hashem and, like Him, is **one essence**.

A participant suggested al-Baqillani may have drawn his idea from the heart's **two great chambers**, one for the intellect and one for the animal life through which the blood flows. "Maybe, maybe."

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## Theory 5: Two Kinds of Air

The soul is a substance made of **two airs** together: the air **within** the body and the air we **breathe in** from outside. Its holders reasoned that to live you must breathe, and the *nefesh* is the life force, so breath must be part of it.

Saadia: no. The purpose of respiration is only **to cool the natural heat of the heart**, as one blows excess smoke away from a fire.

A participant pointed out that this is not true. The Rabbi agreed: "he didn't have the science." But the general point stands: for Saadia breathing is **a purely physical process** of living, and so has nothing to do with the creation of the soul.

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## Theory 6: Anan, the Soul Is the Blood

The sixth theory is that of **Anan ben David**. **Flora** identified him: **the founder of the Karaite schism**. (Karaism arose in the eighth and ninth centuries; it is distinct from the earlier Sadducees.)

Anan held that **the soul is the blood**. It is the blood running through us that gives life, speech and thought. A participant remarked that it is "not completely wrong." "Correct, correct." And as a Karaite he took the Torah literally. His proof is from Devarim: **כי הדם הוא הנפש**, "for the blood is the soul," the reason we may not eat blood.

Saadia answers: Anan forgot the earlier verse in Acharei Mot, **כי נפש הבשר בדם היא**, "the soul of the flesh is **in** the blood." **The blood is the seat of the soul**, its dwelling place. When the soul is happy, the blood is plentiful and a person feels good; when he is worried, the blood drains. There is a very close association, but the soul **sits in** the blood. (The Rabbi corrected the Sefaria page on screen, which had attached the wrong verse to each side.)

When the Torah says "the blood is the soul," that is a way of speaking:

- Mishlei calls wisdom **לב**, the heart: **חסר לב**, "lacking heart," means lacking wisdom. Heart and wisdom are not the same thing; **the heart is the place of wisdom**.

at the Tower of Bavel: "I never realised this, but it's beautiful." **Safah** literally means **a שפה אחת** .**lip**. Language is called "lip" because we speak with our lips

So too, the blood is called the soul because **the soul is in the blood**, not because they are identical.

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## Summary

1. **Essay 6 bridges the book:** the first half established creation, God, revelation, free will and merit; the second turns to resurrection, Mashiach and the world to come. First Saadia asks **what the soul is**.
2. **The soul is created with the body**, joined to it for life, separated at death, and **reunited** when the full number of souls is complete. For Saadia **Olam HaBa** is body and soul, in a world still to come; the Rambam disagrees on both counts. Continual creation of new souls already implies there is no **gilgul**.
3. **Theory 1, the soul as an accident** (Xenocrates' self-moving number, Aristotle's perfection of the body, Hippocrates' four natures, the coordination of the senses, a by-product of blood): rejected because so glorious a being cannot rest on a by-product, and because **an accident cannot bear accidents** such as love, wisdom and sorrow.
4. **Theories 2 and 3, air or fire:** rejected; the soul does not have their natures.
5. **Theory 4, two souls, rational and animal:** rejected. **The soul is one**; its names are synonyms, against the Kabbalistic parts of the soul.
6. **Theory 5, two airs:** rejected; breathing is a physical process.
7. **Theory 6, Anan the Karaite, the soul is the blood:** rejected; **the soul dwells in the blood**, as the heart is the seat of wisdom and the lip the organ of language.

So far, then: the soul is **a separate substance created by God**. It is not air, not fire, not a combination of airs, and it does sit in the blood.

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## Coming Up

Next week: Chapter 2, **Saadia's own definition** of what the soul is.

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